# Deciding with AI

A field guide for getting your digital assistant to actually assist: to think, to choose, and to get unstuck.

**Scan me.** Every prompt in this guide, with copy buttons.

> **You supply the values. The AI supplies options, tradeoffs, and objections. You own the decision.**
> **AI is a tool that talks like a friend. Use it like a tool. Tools break and are not always right for the job.**
> **When AI is not an option, another human is.**

Ask an AI "which is best?" and you get a confident answer with no criteria: best for whom, at what cost? That is the whole decision, and the AI just made it for you by guessing. A good prompt hands over the facts and keeps the values.

| | Weak prompt | Strong prompt |
|---|---|---|
| **You type** | Should I use inheritance or composition? | I'm a Python beginner on a 3-person team with one week. Compare inheritance and composition on build time, ease of understanding, and adding room types later. Don't recommend one. Flag one claim I should verify. |
| **You get** | A verdict that sounds sure | A comparison you can argue with |
| **Who decided** | The AI, by accident | You, on purpose |

## Rules of thumb

When you forget everything else, remember these.

1. **Cheap and reversible? Decide fast.** Save the checking for choices that cost a lot to get wrong.
2. **Commit before you ask.** Write your guess first, or the AI's first answer becomes yours.
3. **Trust scales with how easy a mistake is to catch.** Brainstorming names: loose. A dose or a deadline: never on its word alone.
4. **Specific is checkable, and specific is where inventions hide.** Check names, numbers, quotes, links, and function names first, then check the manual, the documentation, or a peer-reviewed source.
5. **Disagreement is information. Agreement is a clue,** not proof.
6. **The first answer is a draft.** The second round is where it gets good.
7. **If it flatters you, get suspicious.** It can agree with you even when you are wrong. If it caves without new evidence, discount what it said.
8. **Longer is not better.** Ask for the simplest version that works.
9. **Check the one thing that would hurt most if it were wrong.** You can't check everything, so choose.
10. **Vague in, vague out.** Goal, context, limits, format.
11. **A chat that's going in circles won't fix itself.** Restart with a summary.
12. **Private stays private.** When unsure, leave it out.
13. **If your name is on it, you answer for it.**

## What assistants do well, and where they trip

| Great at | Watch out for |
|---|---|
| Gathering and summarizing a lot, fast | Invented facts, sources, and numbers; outdated information |
| Brainstorming options you hadn't thought of | Options it can't know about, because it doesn't know your situation |
| Explaining an idea at your level | Smooth, convincing explanations of things that are wrong |
| Comparing options and spotting risks | Quietly choosing your values for you |
| Breaking a big, scary job into small steps | Plans so long that they become another thing to avoid |
| Patient, tireless, awake at 2 a.m. | It doesn't know when it doesn't know |

## The routine: seven moves

Run them in order for any choice that matters. A small choice needs only moves 1 and 7. The more a mistake costs, the more of the seven you run. Fill in the `[brackets]`.

**1** **Size it**

How much does a wrong choice cost, and can you undo it? Cheap and reversible: decide now and skip to move 7. Costly or permanent: run every move.

**2** **Commit first, then brief the AI**

On paper, before you open any AI: your top three priorities and your gut guess. Then start the chat with a briefing.

THE BRIEFING

```
I need to decide: [the decision, in one sentence].
What I care about, in order: [1], [2], [3].
Limits: [deadline, budget, skills, rules].
My guess: [guess]. I might be wrong.
Don't recommend anything yet. Ask me up to five questions that would change your analysis, one at a time.
```

**3** **Widen**

WIDEN

```
What options haven't I considered, including doing nothing and a cheaper version of each? Is this secretly two decisions?
```

**4** **Compare on your criteria**

COMPARE

```
Compare [A], [B], and [C] on [my criteria]. Rate each 1 to 3 with a one-sentence reason. List your assumptions and one claim I should verify. Don't recommend one, and don't decide which criterion matters most.
```

**5** **Attack your favorite**

ARGUE AGAINST ME

```
I'm leaning toward [choice] because [reason]. Make the strongest case against it. What evidence would change your mind?
```

PREMORTEM

```
It's [three months] from now and this decision failed. Give three likely reasons, and an early warning sign for each.
```

**6** **Cross-check**

Take the claims that matter to a second AI (page 3), then to something outside every chat: a source, a test you run, or a person.

**7** **Decide and log**

Write three lines: **I chose ___. I gave up ___. I'd change my mind if ___.** A decision you can't explain next month was a coin flip.

## Two prompts for any chat

ASSISTANT MODE (PASTE FIRST)

```
Act as my decision assistant. Keep me honest; don't just make me feel good. Ask one question at a time. Point out anything I'm assuming without evidence. When I state a preference, tell me what it costs me. Never choose for me.
```

CLEAN RESTART (WHEN A CHAT WANDERS OR REPEATS A MISTAKE)

```
Summarize this conversation in ten lines: the goal, my criteria, the options, what we verified, and what's still open. I'll paste it into a fresh chat.
```

A role like "decision assistant" sets the tone. It doesn't make the answers more true, so you still check them.

## Catch the AI in a lie

An AI doesn't lie on purpose. It predicts fluent text, and sometimes fluent text is invented: a study that doesn't exist, a function nobody wrote. Think of a brilliant improv actor who never says "I don't know." Confidence tells you nothing, so get a second opinion: open a fresh chat, ideally in a **different** AI, and paste the first answer under one of these.

1 · DID IT LIE?

```
Which statements in this answer are false, outdated, or unsupported? For each, what's true and how could I confirm it? If you're unsure, say so.
```

2 · DID IT MAKE ANYTHING UP?

```
Which names, sources, quotes, numbers, links, or technical terms here might not exist? How do I look each one up?
```

3 · DID IT LEAVE ANYTHING OUT?

```
What options, risks, or viewpoints are missing? Who is affected but never mentioned?
```

4 · DID IT GO OVERBOARD?

```
Where is this overconfident, too long, or too complicated? What's the simplest version that still works?
```

5 · WHAT WOULD MAKE IT BETTER?

```
I'm [one line about me and my goal]. What three changes would make this more useful to me? Write the follow-up question I should send the first AI.
```

6 · WHAT WOULD CHANGE ITS MIND?

```
What evidence would change this conclusion? What's the strongest argument against it?
```

ALL SIX AT ONCE (SHORT ON TIME)

```
Review the answer below like a skeptical colleague. In a short section each: (1) anything false? (2) made up? (3) left out? (4) overboard? (5) what would make it better? (6) what would change your mind? Be blunt.
[paste the answer]
```

**Then don't stop there.** The second AI can be wrong too. Treat its flags as a to-do list, not a verdict. Check each one, and take the real ones back to the first AI: "Another assistant says X is wrong. Show your evidence."

### How much to trust it: the evidence ladder

Climb as high as the stakes demand.

**1** One AI says it · **2** Two AIs agree · **3** A source you opened says it · **4** You ran or tested it · **5** A qualified person confirms it

### Worked example

AI #1 says: "*To get the date three days from now, use* `datetime.today().add_days(3)`." AI #2 flags it: Python's `datetime` has no `add_days`; the usual way is `+ timedelta(days=3)`. Settle it by running both, not by voting. One works and one raises `AttributeError`. That is rung 4, and it took thirty seconds.

## Make the tool teach you

If you don't know what the AI is doing, you haven't learned it. Use it to build your understanding, then test that understanding.

TEACH ME

```
Teach me [topic] at my level. Then quiz me, one question at a time. Don't give an answer until I've tried.
```

TEST ME

```
Here is my explanation of [topic] in my own words: [paste]. What did I get wrong or leave out? Ask me one follow-up question.
```

SHOW ME WHERE TO LOOK

```
Point me to the manual, documentation, or peer-reviewed source for this, so I can check it myself.
```

Do your own research as well: technical documents, manuals, and peer-reviewed work outrank any chat.

## Get unstuck: the garage shelf

Some decisions aren't hard. They're *heavy*. It's the shelf in the garage you've stared at for six weeks, the email you keep not sending, the project you can't start. It isn't complicated; it's living rent-free in your head. An assistant is great at shrinking it down to something you can do before lunch.

EMPTY YOUR HEAD

```
I'm going to dump everything about [the thing]
that's bugging me, messy and in no order. Sort
it into: do now, decide later, and let go. Then
tell me the one thing that matters most.
```

SHRINK IT

```
I've been avoiding [task]. What's the smallest
first step that takes under 15 minutes and needs
no decisions? Then the next one.
```

DEFINE "GOOD ENOUGH"

```
What does "done enough" look like for [task]?
Give me a checklist of no more than five items,
so I know when to stop.
```

KEEP ME ON TASK

```
I'm doing [task] right now. Give me one step at
a time. When I type "done," give me the next
step and nothing else.
```

This is a tool for getting moving, not a substitute for people. If the worry is about more than a task, or it won't let go, talk to someone: a friend, an advisor, or campus counseling.

## Rules for building things with AI

They hold for code, lab reports, and business plans alike. The loop: define, plan, slice, build, test, review, save.

1. **Define "done" first.** Three example inputs and the outputs you expect, or a checklist.
2. **Plan, then build.** "Make a plan and show me before changing anything."
3. **Slice small.** One piece at a time: build it, test it, move on.
4. **Never ship what you can't explain.** If you can't change it without the AI, you don't own it yet.
5. **Run it yourself.** Try odd inputs: empty, huge, unexpected.
6. **Check every name it gives you.** Invented libraries and functions are a real hazard.
7. **Keep save points.** Commit with git before each AI change.
8. **Say how you used it.** Which tool, for what, and how you checked.

## When AI should not decide

| Situation | Use AI for | Then |
|---|---|---|
| Medical, legal, financial, or safety | Preparing better questions; explaining terms | Take the questions to a qualified person. |
| Private data (yours or anyone's) | Nothing, or a fully anonymized version | When unsure, leave it out. |
| Graded work | Only what your syllabus allows | Say what you used it for and how you checked. |
| Decisions about people | Organizing criteria; spotting gaps | A human decides and answers for it. |

**AI is not a professional.** It holds no license and answers to no one. **When AI is not an option, another human is:** an instructor, a classmate, a tutor, a librarian, a friend.

**Your turn: try it in the playground**

Pick one, open two AI tools (or two fresh chats), and run the seven moves.

1. **The class problem.** Three beginners have one week to build a room-reservation program. Inheritance, composition in one file, or composition across modules? Hint: ask whether those are really three options.
2. **A real choice of yours.** A class schedule, a laptop, a project idea. Leave out anything private.
3. **Your garage shelf.** The thing you've been putting off. Run the four unstuck prompts and do the first step today.

**Before you act on any answer, ask:** What would I check? Who's left out? What would make me stop?